Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on John

Literary concepts that **MIGHT** be used in a discussion of the psychology of memory in Browning's "Memorabilia" include

allusion,
apostrophe,
enjambment,
irony,
metaphor,
muse (inspiration),
speaker,
theme, and
tone.

Browning, as speaker, recalls meeting someone who recalls having once met Percy Bysshe Shelley. The contestant might recognize a progression, obvious in the shift from an excitement engendered by meeting someone who has himself met someone famous to an excitement reduced by the laughter that is invoked by memory: the person to whom the speaker is talking laughs at the speaker's being excited that he has met someone, someone who apparently questions Shelley's famousness. The last two stanzas place the importance of the speaker's meeting the person who has met Shelley up against the speaker's own memory of once having crossed a moor, an event that has apparently been reduced to the singularity of remembering his finding an eagle's feather—a molted feather, which feather serves, first, as an artifact recalling the eagle's most recent year of splendor (the feather now "forgotten") and, second, as a metaphor for memory.

The young writer might focus on the memory's inability to sustain itself in emotional terms, down to the point at which the poem's last line, perhaps ironically, reminds us that memory fails unless there is a physical object to remind: memorabilia.

The writer might recognize the distance travelled during recollection as metaphorically the same as the distance traveled across a moor that might have some "use in the world no doubt"—a moor/a life/a memory that every now then has had a moment that "shines alone" (line 11), that stands out like the eagle feather, which itself has had a life of its own but is now but a memory: not unlike the degree of separation that defines Browning's speaker having met someone who had met someone . . . .